

***Figure 6.6*** *Large temple, Ambh Sharif, West Panjab, Pakistan. © Photograph Alka Patel 1997.*

ever-changing course. In fact, just a century after the Shansabani campaign (and of course unanticipated by Mu'izz al-Din at the time), Banbhore–Dibul itself would experience a dramatic contraction of trade traffic as the Indus shifted several kilometers to the east, displacing Banbhore–Dibul in favor of Lahori Bandar as the principal riverine port.[31] Nevertheless, at the time of the Ghazna Shansabanis' entry into this world, Banbhore–Dibul and nearby commercial centers and ports still served as proverbial lynchpins along the Indus, connecting worldwide Indian Ocean littorals with the overland travel routes spanning the Eurasian landmass.

In large part thanks to the sustained commercial and cultural connections of the continuous coastline of Gujarat, Sindh, and Makran, the settlement of West Asian populations here and farther inland is documentable since the early historic era.[32] Rather than disrupting this flow of people and ideas, the emergence of Islam as an identifiable set of socio-religious affiliations and practices easily fit within the networks interconnecting essentially the entire "Old World." The immigration and integration of Muslim communities into the polities of the western coasts of the Indian subcontinent, then, was far from a novelty by the late twelfth century. Polities ruled by Muslim elites in this region – or with substantial presences of Muslims – were the result not only of the earlier 'Umayyad through Ghaznavid incursions (cf. Chapters 2 and 3), they were also sustained by local peoples with long histories of conversion to Islam and Islamization.[33]

To date, scholarly works on coastal northwestern India have – perhaps understandably –focused on the prosperous mercantile and other elites inhabiting the cosmopolitan urban centers dotting the region (cf. above and Bibliography). However, surviving material indices remind us of the participation of other, understudied populations in creating the regional dynamic of an *inclusive* cosmopolitanism, wherein multiple socio-religious mores and cultural forms coexisted. The late tenth-century influx of the Saljuq confederacies into the Iranian world, and their gradual extension